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BATTLE FOR HORMUZ ESCALATES

Trump gives Iran 48 hours to open Strait, Riyadh expels Iranian staff

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The focus of the war has sharply shifted to the Strait of Hormuz, with tensions escalating after US President Donald Trump issued a 48-hour ultimatum to Iran to reopen the vital oil route — or face devastating strikes.

Iran yesterday responded with sweeping threats, warning it would target key infrastructure across the Middle East if Washington follows through on its vow to “obliterate” the Islamic republic’s power plants.

In a post on Truth Social, Trump warned that if Iran did not fully reopen the strait “within 48 hours,” the United States would strike its power infrastructure. Tehran’s military command said any such move would trigger attacks on US-linked “energy, information technology and desalination infrastructure” across the region — signalling a dangerous widening of the conflict.

Critical escalation

The standoff marks a critical escalation centred on Hormuz, the narrow chokepoint through which around a fifth of global oil flows. Traffic has slowed to a near standstill, with only a fraction of vessels attempting passage amid attacks and threats.

Iran has maintained that the strait remains open to countries it considers friendly, while warning it will block vessels linked to its “enemies.” But



UAE Presidential Court

■ President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan received Hakan Fidan, Minister of Foreign Affairs of Turkey on Friday. The meeting addressed the ongoing military escalation in the region and its serious implications for regional and international security and stability.

disruptions have already rattled markets, with oil prices rising and supply chains under pressure.

UAE reports new attacks

Iran has broadened its response across the region. Saudi Arabia said it detected ballistic missiles near Riyadh and intercepted drones, while the UAE reported new missile and drone attacks.

UAE air defence systems on March 22 intercepted four ballistic missiles and 25 UAVs launched from Iran. Since the start of Iranian aggression, UAE

forces have intercepted 345 ballistic missiles, 15 cruise missiles and 1,773 UAVs.

The attacks have resulted in the deaths of two armed forces personnel and six civilians of multiple nationalities, while 160 people have been injured, according to officials. The Ministry of Defence said it remains fully prepared to counter threats and safeguard national security.

Adding to regional concern, Iran also attempted a long-range missile strike on the US-UK base at Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean — a distance

of around 4,000 kilometres — though the attack did not succeed.

Diplomatic voices in the Gulf warned of the broader implications. Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said Iran’s actions carry “profound geopolitical implications” and reinforce the centrality of the Iranian threat in Gulf strategic thinking.

Gargash said: “Iran’s brutal aggression reinforces its threat as a central axis in GCC strategic thinking and underscores the distinct nature of Gulf security, independent of

Iran’s brutal aggression reinforces its threat as a central axis in GCC strategic thinking and underscores the distinct nature of Gulf security, independent of traditional concepts of Arab security.”

Dr Anwar Gargash
| Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President

traditional concepts of Arab security. The missiles, drones and aggressive rhetoric are Iranian, and the result is a strengthened drive to enhance our national capabilities, reinforce collective Gulf security, and deepen our security partnerships with Washington.” He added: “This is the cost of Iran’s miscalculations.”

‘Flagrant violation’ of international law

Saudi Arabia also sharply condemned Iran’s attacks, calling them a “flagrant violation” of international law and regional agreements.

The kingdom ordered several Iranian military officials to leave within 24 hours, declaring them persona non grata, and said it would take “all necessary measures” to protect its security and territory under Article 51 of the UN Charter.

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Dubai Walk project set to transform mobility

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

Dubai’s Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) has awarded the first contract under its sweeping Dubai Walk Master Plan.

The project, centred in the historic Al Ras district, signals the start of a long-term transformation aimed at reshaping how residents and visitors move through the city, prioritising walking, cycling and seamless public transport integration.

The Dubai Walk Master Plan aims to deliver more than 6,000 kilometres of walkways across the emirate by 2040.

The Al Ras development, part of Phase I of Dubai Walk, will introduce 12km of pedestrian walkways and 5km of cycling tracks, while carefully preserving the district’s historic identity through context-sensitive urban design.

FULL REPORT P2

Distance learning boosts UAE education sector’s resilience

Smart classrooms keep students learning seamlessly during emergencies

ABU DHABI

The distance learning system in the UAE represents a key pillar ensuring the continuity of the educational process and the flexibility of implementing academic plans under various circumstances.

The country has developed an advanced and adaptable education system capable of responding swiftly to changes and emergencies without compromising quality or continuity.

The decision to continue distance learning in public and private schools for two weeks reflects the high level of readiness of educational institutions and their ability to transition immediately to alternative learning models that ensure the smooth continuation of education.

Digital infrastructure

The move highlights the UAE’s advanced capabilities in



The decision to continue distance learning in public and private schools for two weeks reflects the high level of readiness of educational institutions.

digital infrastructure, which support smart learning and enable students and teachers to continue the educational process efficiently from any location.

This transformation stems

from a forward-looking vision adopted by the UAE years ago. In 2012, the Mohammed Bin Rashid Smart Learning Programme was launched, forming a key milestone in the development of the country’s education sector.

It contributed to reshaping the learning environment within schools through the introduction of smart classrooms and the use of modern interactive technologies, alongside the development of advanced digital infrastructure supporting the shift towards digital education.

Modernising curricula

The initiative also focused on modernising curricula, fostering innovation and critical thinking among students, and providing digital platforms that allow parents to track academic progress and stay connected with schools and teachers.

The UAE model of distance learning underscores that sustained investment in digital education and smart technologies forms a solid foundation for ensuring the continuity and advancement of learning outcomes.

—WAM

2 Indians among 4 killed in Oman floods

More than 40 rescued as search operations continue for missing person

DUBAI
BY LEKSHMY PAVITHRAN
Assistant Online Editor

Four people, including two Indians, have lost their lives as flash floods struck Oman on Saturday.

On Saturday night, rescue teams confirmed that three people had died and more than 40 others were rescued after heavy rains swept across parts of Oman. Search operations continued for another missing person.

The fatalities occurred in South Al Batinah Governorate after three vehicles were caught in fast-moving floodwaters in Wadi Al Maawil. Rescue teams saved one individual, while search operations later confirmed the deaths of the three others.

Flooding in valleys and low-lying areas disrupted transport routes. Elsewhere, emergency crews carried out multiple rescue missions as

The fatalities occurred in South Al Batinah Governorate after three vehicles were caught in fast-moving floodwaters.

heavy runoff cut off roads in parts of Muscat and the Al Batinah coastal belt. The deceased Indians have been named as Yusuf (38) from Kootanad, Thrithala, and Shamla (32) from Kotappadam, Thrithala, in Kerala according to Math-rubhumi.

Rain, strong winds to hit parts of UAE

Convective cloud formation is expected to bring rainfall and fresh to strong winds across parts of the UAE. The conditions which began yesterday are expected to last till Friday, with blowing dust and sand likely to reduce visibility, according to the National Centre of Meteorology (NCM)

SEE ALSO P2